THY KINGDOM COME

VOLUME ONE

The World Dossier

A story and scripture companion for the drafting and revision of the novel. Kept by its author, and revised as the manuscript revises itself.

DANY · OCTOBER 2026

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

VOLUME ONE

Contents

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What this companion is

This is a working reference for a novel about a Christian empire, kept by the person writing it. *Thy Kingdom Come* can't be written honestly by someone guessing at scripture, and it can't be written well by someone who has only absorbed the version of scripture that power finds convenient. So the companion does two jobs at once. It teaches the book patiently and from the beginning, as literature, as history, and as an argument that has never stopped arguing with itself. And it keeps a record of what the Empire does to that book once it has the authority to quote it.

It isn't a devotional and it isn't a study guide. Nothing in here asks you to arrive at a settled conclusion about God, and nothing hands you a single meaning for a passage people have fought over for two thousand years. Where a reading is contested, the contest is printed. Where the text is stranger, more violent or more tender than its reputation, that's printed too. You're being handed summaries, analysis, references and tools that send you back to the text itself. Volume One is the world: the scripture the Empire inherited, and the history, institutions, beliefs and places that produced Eden's story. The people and the chapters belong to Volume Two. When a fact about the world matters to one particular person, this volume points to her dossier instead of working it out here. Above all, this is a book you're allowed to ruin. Write in the margins, argue with the entries, cross out anything the drafting proves false, and date the page when you do. The manuscript is the authority here, and this companion serves it. When the two disagree, the manuscript wins and this book gets amended.

"Every empire that has ever quoted a holy book has also decided which parts of it were quotable."

WHAT IT ISN'T

A devotional. A curriculum. A settled theology. An apologetic, in either direction. A book with the right answer at the back.

MARGINALIA

How to use it

There's an order to this book, and it's worth following the first time through. The parts move outward from the text itself to the empire that interprets it, and then into the world that empire built: its fall, its institutions, its twelve Dominions and its Trials. You can read a single entry in ten minutes or spend an afternoon on one. Both are legitimate uses.

Work in one of two modes. In study mode you're simply learning, reading an entry with no scene in mind and letting the margins fill with whatever surprises you. In drafting mode you come in with a scene that isn't working, find the entry or the doctrine page that touches it, and take only what you need. The canon register and the logs at the back keep the second mode fast. They're the book's memory, and they only work if you write in them the day you discover something. Discoveries are the real product. If an entry teaches you that a passage the Empire loves is addressed to slaveholders, or that the woman you'd cast as a warning is the only person in her chapter who tells the truth, that's a change to the novel. It belongs in the discovery log at the back, with a date, so that six months from now you can tell the difference between something you decided and something you only absorbed. Nothing here has to be finished. A half-filled page is more useful than a blank one.

The working arc

1. Learn the book before anyone tells you what it means.
2. Recognize its people and its patterns on sight.
3. Watch how power reads it, and what power leaves out.
4. Build the Empire's religion on purpose, doctrine by doctrine.
5. Know the world well enough that every room in it has a history.
6. Apply it to the manuscript, then record what changed.

Two modes

Study

No scene in mind. Read, take notes, follow the cross-references.

Drafting

A scene that resists. Take only what the scene needs, and go.

Marginalia

✣ *See also:* the Canon Register and the Discovery Log, at the back.

Reading the page

The layout carries meaning. Once you know the five signals below, you can tell at a glance whether you're reading the text, reading the Empire, reading an argument with no settled answer, or looking at space that belongs to you. The signals hold in black and white, because most of this book will be photocopied at some point.

INFORMATION

Plain roman type with no rule beside it. The text and its history, reported as plainly as the material allows. Where the material is disputed, the entry says so.

SCRIPTURE

> *Your desire shall be for your husband, and he shall rule over you.*
> GENESIS 3.16

Quoted text is italic behind a single fine rule, with the reference beneath it in small tracked capitals.

WHAT THE EMPIRE DOES WITH IT

The heavy frame with the pink edge, and the only one in the book. Anything marked this way is the Empire's reading, not the text's. Someone made that decision, and the novel is free to expose it.

CONTESTED

A broken frame means the companion isn't deciding. Contested always names a real biblical, historical, linguistic or theological dispute among serious readers. It's different from Possible, which marks an idea of your own that you haven't approved.

YOURS

Ruled space, on nearly every working page. If it's ruled, it's yours.

✤ Cross-references sit at the foot of the outer column, never inside a sentence, so following one is a choice and not an interruption.

Labels and sources

In the scripture parts (I to IV), unlabeled prose is research: what the text or scholarship says, with scholars named where a position belongs to them. Your own canon carries a source tag and no label. Everything else is labeled at the start of the sentence it governs.

LABEL	WHAT IT MEANS
RESEARCH	Outside fact, with a source. Unlabeled in Parts I to IV.
INTERPRETATION	A reading of the material, offered as a reading
CONTESTED	A real scholarly or theological dispute
INFERENCE	A conclusion drawn from your files that they don't state
POSSIBLE	An idea worth considering, and not canon
OPEN QUESTION	Something you still have to decide
CONFLICT	Two of your sources disagree
SUPERSEDED	Older material that no longer controls
DECIDED	A call you've made. Canon from here on.

TAG	SOURCE
FR 0–44	Final Rulings, by number. These outrank everything.
TL	Timeline Updated
TR	The Covenant Trials Updated
TR-ORIG	The original Trials file, where the update is silent
DOM	The Dominions Update
MEN	Men in the Covenant Empire
CR	The Crownward
DR3	Draft Three (Chapter One so far)
WR	Writing Rules
AM	The Audit Master, the old Companion
RULING	A ruling you made in the calibration doc or since

The eight parts

Each part carries a mark on its divider and in the running heads, so the book can be found by thumb as well as by contents. The parts are cumulative: the later ones assume you've at least skimmed the earlier ones.

PART	WHAT'S IN IT
✣ I	Learning the Bible as a novelist. Bible 101, canon, genres, translation, reading in context, contested readings, the sixty-six books, seven focused study spreads and four deep-dive dossiers.
✦ II	The people of the text. The women, then the men: what they're usually reduced to, and what the text actually gives you.
† III	Jesus, kingdom and power. Authority, bodies, women and money, the Lord's Prayer a clause at a time, and the Gospel Grid.
▣ IV	Empire and interpretation. The empires of the Bible, who gets to say what it means, the passages put to work and the passages kept quiet, and American history from the Puritans to now.
✚ V	The Fall of the United States. The timeline, the competing histories, the Restoration Act, living memory and the founder files.
❦ VI	Building the Empire. The Triune Rule, the Crownward, the Temple, the Registry, doctrine and lived religion, and the household order.
◈ VII	The twelve Dominions, one by one.
⌖ VIII	The Covenant Trials as an institution.
≡ BACK	The canon register, sources and editions, the open questions and the discovery log.

WHERE I WANT TO START, AND WHY

WHERE I WANT TO START, AND WHY

THE TEST

Every page in this book answers to the question at the foot of this one.

MARGINALIA

Rules of the House

Seven commitments that keep this companion honest. They're the difference between a novel that takes religion seriously and one that uses it as set dressing.

I · THE TEXT ISN'T THE EMPIRE	Every entry keeps them apart, because the engine of this novel is the gap between what a passage says and what an institution can make it do.
II · CONTESTED STAYS CONTESTED	Where scholars and traditions genuinely disagree, the disagreement is printed and left standing. The Empire may settle a question. The companion doesn't.
III · NO CHARACTER IS AN ALLEGORY	A biblical parallel can light a character up, and it never maps onto her. Every parallel ends with where it breaks, and the break is usually where the character gets interesting.
IV · BELIEF HAS A COST AND A TEACHER	Nobody in this book believes anything for free. Someone taught it to them, and something's at stake in keeping it. Both go in the dossier.
V · DISCOVERY OUTRANKS PLAN	If the research contradicts the outline, the research gets a hearing. The outline is a hypothesis, and this is where it gets tested.
VI · NOTHING ENTERS THE NOVEL UNTESTED	Every borrowed symbol, doctrine and parallel has to answer one question before it earns a scene.
VII · POSSIBLE ISN'T CANON	Freewriting, inference and research notes stay marked until you approve them. A compelling idea stays possible until it survives the manuscript, the source files and your own decision.

"Does this serve Thy Kingdom Come, or does it only prove I did the reading?"

Before you begin

Answer these once, in ink, before you read a single entry, and don't go back and tidy the answers later. The point is a record of where you started, so that in a year you can see what the reading did to you and how much of it belongs to the novel.

WHAT I ALREADY BELIEVE THE BIBLE SAYS, AND WHERE I LEARNED IT

WHAT I'M AFRAID I'LL FIND IN IT

WHAT THE EMPIRE IS FOR, IN ONE SENTENCE I'D DEFEND

WHAT I DON'T YET UNDERSTAND ABOUT MY OWN NOVEL

DECIDED **DATE**

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

I

PART ONE · ✣

Learning the Bible as a Novelist

✣

You can't write about people who've been handed a holy book until you've read what they were handed. Start here, and keep your objections in the margin.

i · What the Bible actually is	014
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OT NT

THE NUMBERS

66 books in the Protestant count · 39 Old, 27 New · Hebrew, Aramaic, Greek · roughly a thousand years of writing · no single author, no single editor, no original title page.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* How it was assembled · Who gets to say what it means, Part IV.

What the Bible actually is

The first thing to understand, and the thing most people who grew up around this book were never told, is that it's a library. Sixty-six separate documents in the Protestant count, written across something like a thousand years, in three languages, by many hands, for audiences who mostly didn't know the other documents existed. Some of it is law written for a small farming people. Some is court history written to support a dynasty. Some is poetry, some is prophecy shouted at a government, and some is letters from a traveling preacher to congregations he was trying to hold together.

The variety is the most useful fact you can hold onto as a novelist, because it means the Bible has an argument going on inside it. Deuteronomy ties faithfulness to flourishing, and Job gives a righteous man catastrophe and lets his friends make the simple version of that argument until it fails. Ezra sends the foreign wives away, and Ruth makes a foreign woman the great-grandmother of the king. Proverbs says wisdom generally pays, and Ecclesiastes says the pattern doesn't hold. Nobody smoothed these out. They sit in the same volume, and every institution that has used this book has had to choose which side of each argument would be the official one. **INTERPRETATION** The choosing is your novel. The Empire doesn't have a Bible problem. It has a Bible strategy, and it's the one scriptural empires have usually used: lift the passages about order, hierarchy and submission into the plain and permanent word of God, and file the passages about jubilee, debt release, foreign widows, prophets who insult kings and a messiah executed by the state under poetry or instructions for another time. Nothing has to be deleted. The canon stays intact and the pulpit still cites chapter and verse. All it takes is a consistent policy about which parts are read aloud, and to whom. So read it as a library with an argument in it. When you meet a passage, the useful question is what it says, which side of the internal argument it's on, who benefits from that side winning, and what it would cost a character to have been raised hearing only one half.

"A canon is the list of things a religion has agreed to keep arguing about."

How it was assembled

No angel delivered a table of contents. The collection you can buy in an airport was assembled slowly, by communities, customs and arguments, over centuries, and the process left visible seams. They're worth knowing about, because your Empire will be running the same process on purpose.

On the Hebrew side the Torah settled first, then the prophetic books, then a looser third group, the Writings, which stayed unsettled for a long time. Some books nearly didn't make it. Esther was questioned partly because God is never named in it. Song of Songs was questioned because it's frankly erotic, and it took a great deal of allegory to make it respectable. Ecclesiastes was questioned because it sounds close to faithless. INTERPRETATION The books that struggled were the ones hardest to use as instruction. On the Christian side the process was slower and messier. For the first centuries there was no fixed New Testament, only a widening pool of gospels, letters and apocalypses circulating unevenly between cities. Lists were proposed, disputed and revised. The four gospels that were kept weren't the only ones written. Revelation was long resisted in the Greek-speaking East, and other apocalypses dropped out entirely. Emperors funded copies and convened councils, and Nicaea in 325 wasn't about the canon. By the time Athanasius listed the twenty-seven books in 367, the shortlist was largely settled, by habit as much as by ruling. Two things follow for TKC. INTERPRETATION Whoever can convene, fund, copy and distribute has outsized influence over which texts stay in circulation. And once a canon closes, the arguing doesn't stop. It moves from which books to which verses. The Empire inherits a closed canon, so it does all its work through emphasis, translation, the calendar of readings and commentary, which is quieter editing and much harder to catch.

WHAT THE EMPIRE WOULD DO WITH THIS

POSSIBLE Never touch the canon. Touch the calendar. Decide which passages are read in public worship, which are kept for clergy, which appear in schoolbooks, and which are never printed in the cheap edition sent out to the Dominions.

BOOKS THAT NEARLY LOST

Esther · Song of Songs · Ecclesiastes · Hebrews · James · 2 Peter · Jude · Revelation

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* The canon timeline, ii.3 · Passages kept quiet, Part IV.

GEN–DEUT
JOSH–RUTH
1 SAM–2 CHR
EZRA–ESTH
JOB–SONG
ISA–MAL

The shape of the Old Testament

Thirty-nine books in the Protestant count, and the plot beneath all of them is land: getting it, losing it, and living under someone else's empire on it. Learn the six movements and you'll always know roughly where you're standing.

TORAH · GENESIS TO DEUTERONOMY	Origins, a family, slavery, escape, and a law given in a desert to a people who don't have a country yet. Everything later quotes or argues with these five books.
CONQUEST AND JUDGES · JOSHUA TO RUTH	Taking the land, then failing to hold together. Judges is the most brutal stretch in the collection and ends with a line that works as a political thesis: everyone did what was right in his own eyes, because there was no king. Ruth answers it with a foreigner.
MONARCHY · SAMUEL TO CHRONICLES	A people demand a king, are warned in detail what a king will take, and get one anyway. Dynasty, temple, civil war and succession by murder follow. Chronicles retells the same reigns with some of the embarrassing material left out.
EXILE AND RETURN · EZRA TO ESTHER	The state is destroyed and the population deported, and the survivors work out how to be a people without a country. A partial return, a rebuilt wall, a crisis about foreign wives, and a queen in a foreign court in a book that never names God.
WISDOM AND POETRY · JOB TO SONG OF SONGS	Where the tradition argues with itself most openly: Job accusing God of injustice, a hymnbook that includes rage, orderly proverbs, a book that calls everything vapor, and a love poem.
PROPHETS · ISAIAH TO MALACHI	Mostly political speech to the powerful, about idolatry and about the treatment of the poor, the widow, the foreigner and the worker. Some of it looks ahead. Most of it addresses its own moment. This is the section every empire handles most carefully, and the one your resistance will quote.

CONTESTED

Whether the conquest narratives record history, later national memory, or theology told as narrative is genuinely disputed. Your Empire will read them as precedent for holy war, and your dissidents as a small kingdom explaining itself.

WHICH MOVEMENT THE EMPIRE TEACHES AS ITS OWN STORY

The shape of the New Testament

Twenty-seven documents, all written inside the Roman Empire by members of a movement with no political power, most of them within about seventy years of a public execution. The situation shapes everything, including the parts your Empire will most want to use.

GOSPELS · MATTHEW TO JOHN	Four accounts of one life, and they don't match, which is the most useful thing about them. Mark is urgent and bleak, Matthew argues that this fulfills the Law, Luke keeps putting women and the poor in the frame, and John does high theology. Read side by side, you're watching four communities decide what mattered. See the Gospel Grid in Part III.
ACTS · THE MOVEMENT SPREADS	A small, property-sharing sect argues its way across the Mediterranean, mostly in rented rooms and courtrooms. Again and again it's hosted by women with houses.
PAUL'S LETTERS · ROMANS TO PHILEMON	Occasional letters, and no systematic theology. Each is one side of a conversation with a particular congregation in a particular crisis. Lift a verse out of that and you're quoting an answer while hiding the question.
GENERAL LETTERS · HEBREWS TO JUDE	Written to scattered communities under pressure. James is blunt about the rich, and the letters under Peter's name are about living faithfully without power.
REVELATION · APOCALYPTIC	Resistance literature in symbols, written for believers under an empire that called itself divine. INTERPRETATION Many scholars read the beast as imperial Rome and Babylon as its capital, and the book as a claim that Rome won't last. Read as a timetable for the far future, it loses its first readers. Read as a banned pamphlet, it's the most politically dangerous book in the collection.

> **THE CENTRAL IRONY FOR TKC**
>
> INTERPRETATION Every document here was written by people with no power, about a man the state executed, for readers the state despised. The Empire runs its theology on literature written by the losing side, and the material for its own undoing is bound into the volume it hands out.

THE NEW TESTAMENT BOOK MY EMPIRE WOULD LEAST LIKE A GIRL TO READ FIRST

THE GENRE TEST

Before a character quotes anything at anyone: what kind of writing is this, who was it addressed to, and what does the speaker gain by treating it as a rule?

MARGINALIA

The genres, and why they matter

Reading a poem as a statute is one of the most common ways this book gets turned into a weapon. A lament isn't a doctrine. A proverb is a general pattern that its own collection contradicts elsewhere. Name what you're holding before you decide what it obliges anyone to do.

LAW	Binding instruction for a particular covenant community in a particular economy. Ask who it's addressed to and what it replaced.
NARRATIVE	Stories describe far more than they endorse. The Bible reports polygamy, slavery and massacre without approving them.
POETRY	Compressed, figurative, built on parallel lines. It carries feeling. A great deal of harm done with scripture comes from reading a metaphor flat.
WISDOM	Observed patterns offered as advice, deliberately in tension across books. Proverbs and Ecclesiastes are meant to be read against each other.
PROPHECY	Public address, usually to rulers, usually conditional: change this or the consequence follows. Some of it looks far ahead, and most of it speaks to its own day.
LETTER	One side of a correspondence about a local crisis. Every general rule you pull out of it has a particular quarrel behind it.
GOSPEL	Ancient biography with an argument. Each writer selects, orders and shapes to persuade a particular community.
APOCALYPTIC	Symbolic writing for people under pressure. Its symbols were readable to its first readers and point at the powers of their own day.

✣ *See also:* How to read a passage in context, vii.

Translation, and which one to trust

Every translation is a set of decisions. Someone had to decide whether a Greek word describing a woman in a congregation means servant or deacon, whether an instruction is addressed to wives or to everyone, and whether an ambiguous phrase gets resolved toward hierarchy or toward mutuality. Most of those decisions are honest attempts with a hard word. Some carry theological commitments, and the committees that make them have confessions, funders and readers in mind.

For your purposes the method is simple. Read any passage that matters in at least two translations from different traditions, and when they diverge, stop, because the divergence is where the interesting work is. **POSSIBLE** The Empire lives in that gap. An empire that controls the official edition doesn't need to lie. It only needs to keep choosing the harder rendering, generation after generation, until the gentler reading sounds like a modern invention. Translations sit on a spectrum. Some aim at word-for-word fidelity and read stiffly. Some aim at thought-for-thought clarity and smooth over difficulty. Some are paraphrases with a strong voice. None of these is dishonest by definition, but the smoother the English, the more interpretive decisions have already been made for you out of sight. Chapters and verses aren't original either. They were added centuries later for finding passages, and they've made the whole book quotable in fragments, which is exactly the format a state needs for slogans, wall inscriptions and school recitation.

THE EMPIRE'S EDITION

POSSIBLE Decide early what the Empire's authorized text is, who may own a different one, what has been footnoted into harmlessness, and which single word in the household passages the Temple's authority rests on. A translation dispute is a perfectly good inciting incident.

METHOD

TWO MINIMUM

Two translations from different traditions. Note every divergence. The gap is the material.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Translation, module vi · the household verse, module ix.

METHOD

JOB 42.7

EPH 5.21–33

How to read a passage in context

Eight questions, in this order, every time. Run them and you'll read better than many people who quote this book professionally, and you'll be able to write clergy who are sophisticated and not merely sinister.

I · WHAT KIND OF TEXT	Name the genre first: law, story, poem, letter, oracle, apocalypse. It decides what kind of claim the passage can make.
II · WHO'S SPEAKING	The narrator, a character, God as quoted by a character, an opponent being paraphrased, or a friend the book will prove wrong. Job's comforters get pages of confident theology that the book itself rejects (42:7).
III · TO WHOM	A named congregation, a king, a nation, an enslaved population, a household. An instruction to the powerful reads very differently when it's turned on the powerless, and that turn is one of the commonest abuses there is.
IV · WHAT COMES BEFORE AND AFTER	Read the paragraph on either side, then the chapter, then skim the book's argument. A verse used as a wall inscription almost always has a sentence beside it that complicates it.
V · WHAT WORLD PRODUCED IT	The economy, the legal status of women and slaves, who owned land, what an honor culture punished. The point is to see what the text was arguing with. Sometimes it's more radical than its setting, and sometimes far less.
VI · WHAT THE WORDS DO	Check a second translation on any word carrying weight. If two respectable versions disagree, you've found a decision and not a fact.
VII · WHO GAINS	Ask it of the passage and of every reading of it, including the ones you like. Interpretations have beneficiaries.
VIII · WHAT IT COSTS	Who has to carry the consequence if this reading is enforced. The answer usually names the character in your novel who lives inside the doctrine.

A PASSAGE I'VE ONLY EVER HEARD WITH QUESTION III SKIPPED

EPH 5.21–33

COL 3.18–4.1

1 PET 2.18–3.7

P46 · VATICANUS

ARISTOTLE, POLITICS I

THE HOUSEHOLD VERSE

A WORKED EXAMPLE

Take the passage scriptural empires have built household law on: the instruction to wives in Ephesians. Run the eight questions and see how much of the standard use depends on stopping early. The full treatment is in module ix.

> *Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord.*
>
> EPHESIANS 5.22, QUOTED ALONE, AS IT APPEARS ON A WALL

GENRE	A letter to congregations, not a statute.
THE SENTENCE BEFORE	"Submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ" (5:21), addressed to everyone. In some of the earliest manuscripts, P46 and Codex Vaticanus among them, 5:22 has no verb of its own and borrows "submitting" from 5:21. Cut 5:21 and a mutual instruction reads as a one-way command.
THE PASSAGE AFTER	Addressed to husbands and much longer, about 116 Greek words to the wives' 40 by one count. Husbands are told to love three times and to give themselves up as Christ did. They're never told to rule, enforce or correct.
THE WORLD	Household codes were a known form. Aristotle's ran master over slave, husband over wife, father over children. Ephesians speaks to wives, children and slaves as moral agents and gives the stronger party duties. **INTERPRETATION** Read against its setting, it modifies an existing hierarchy. An empire that wants it timeless has to keep the setting out of view.
THE WORDS	**CONTESTED** Whether "head" (*kephalē*) means authority, source or prominence. The verb *hypotassō* means to arrange oneself under, and how much weight its middle voice can bear is argued.
WHO GAINS	Whoever is allowed to quote the fragment and forbidden to read the frame.

What the fragment is for

EPH 5.21–33

MODULE IX

WHAT THE EMPIRE DOES

POSSIBLE Prints the fragment, leaves out the mutual line, shortens the husbands' section in the Dominion edition, and sets the whole thing to music so children learn it before they read it.

WHAT THIS GIVES TKC

POSSIBLE A scene where a character reads the missing line for the first time. It's a revelation about editing, which is worse than a revelation about God, because it means somebody chose.

WHERE MY NOVEL PRINTS THE FRAGMENT, AND WHERE IT PRINTS THE FRAME

FAULT LINES

MODULE VIII

Contested readings

These are the fault lines. Each has been argued in good faith for centuries by people who know the languages, and no amount of reading settles them. **POSSIBLE** For the novel they're gifts. A doctrine the Empire has closed is a doctrine still quietly open somewhere in the Empire, and every one of these is a possible conflict between characters.

HEADSHIP

Whether the household passages set a permanent order of authority or address one culture's arrangements. Both readings have long histories, and neither is fringe.

SLAVERY

Whether the letters accommodate an existing institution, quietly undermine it, or endorse it. Both sides of the American abolition fight quoted scripture fluently.

OBEDIENCE TO RULERS

Romans 13 says authorities are appointed by God. The same collection is full of prophets defying kings and apostles refusing magistrates.

PURITY AND THE BODY

Which purity laws were ritual, which moral, which binding, and who decides. The line drawn here sets what your Empire can regulate about a woman's body and call faith.

WOMEN SPEAKING

One letter silences women in assembly, and the same author greets women leading congregations and names one an apostle. How those fit is a live dispute.

DIVINE VIOLENCE

Whether the conquest commands are history, rhetoric, or a later people's theology of their own past. Holy war in your novel rests on which answer the Empire teaches.

WEALTH

Whether prosperity signals blessing or is itself the danger. Deuteronomy and the prophets pull in opposite directions, and a ruling class finds the first easier to preach.

THE END OF THINGS

Whether apocalyptic language describes a coming event, a present reality, or a verdict on a particular empire. A state that teaches the first can promise anything.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH SIDE THE EMPIRE TEACHES, AND WHO IN MY NOVEL DISAGREES

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

I–II

MODULES

What It Is How It Came Together

The library, its four collections, and the thousand years it took to decide what was in it

TEN PAGES

INFORMATION

CANON

TANAKH · LXX

I.1

What the Bible actually is

A library, not a book. Sixty-six documents in the Protestant collection this companion starts from, written across roughly a thousand years, in three languages, by people who didn't know they were contributing to the same volume, and who sometimes argued with each other.

WHICH BIBLE THIS COMPANION USES, AND WHY THAT NEEDS SAYING

We start with the sixty-six-book Protestant canon, because it's the Bible in the room where you were raised and the Bible the Empire inherited. It isn't the only one. Jewish tradition holds twenty-four books in three divisions and doesn't arrange them as an Old Testament. Catholic Bibles include the deuterocanonical books. Orthodox collections include those and more, and differ among themselves, and the Ethiopian Orthodox canon is the largest of all. The shape of the collection is itself an argument about what scripture is for.

THE INTERNAL CONVERSATIONS

THE TENSION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE
DEUTERONOMY AND JOB	Deuteronomy ties covenant faithfulness to flourishing. Job gives a righteous man catastrophe and lets his friends make the simple version of that argument until it fails. The dispute is over retribution used as a rule.
EZRA AND RUTH	Ezra–Nehemiah dissolves foreign marriages as restoration policy. Ruth makes a Moabite woman David's great-grandmother. Two answers to the same question about who belongs.
PROVERBS AND ECCLESIASTES	Proverbs teaches that wisdom can be learned and generally pays. Ecclesiastes watches the same world and reports that the pattern doesn't hold.
COURT AND PROPHET	The court histories tell kingship from inside the palace. The prophets address the same kings from outside, about the poor, the widow, the foreigner and the worker, and also about idolatry, false worship and foreign alliances.

THE WORKING LENS

INTERPRETATION The Bible holds many voices, priestly and prophetic, royal and exilic, addressing different crises. Read these as tensions inside one tradition, not as authors calling each other liars. When a character quotes scripture as if it has one settled opinion, that character is making a choice worth writing about.

Four collections

TANAKH
LXX
TRENT 1546
ETHIOPIAN CANON

The same core, different edges, a different order, and the order is an argument. Where a collection ends tells you what it thinks the story is about.

COLLECTION	BOOKS	HOW IT'S ARRANGED	WHERE IT ENDS
Tanakh (Jewish)	24	Torah, Prophets (Nevi'im), Writings (Ketuvim). A complete scripture, not an "Old Testament."	Chronicles, with Cyrus's decree to go up and rebuild. The story closes on return.
Protestant	66	39 Old Testament books (the Tanakh's books, counted and ordered differently, with the Prophets moved to the end) and 27 New	Malachi, then Revelation. The Hebrew scriptures end on a promise, which frames them as a prologue.
Catholic	73	Adds the deuterocanonical books: Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch, 1–2 Maccabees, and additions to Esther and Daniel	Includes the Maccabean revolt, armed resistance to an empire that outlawed the faith
Orthodox	76 or more	Varies by communion. Greek, Slavonic and Ethiopian traditions differ from each other and from Rome.	No single answer. Canon has never been uniform worldwide.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION It gave the Protestant New Testament twenty-eight books. It has twenty-seven.

FOUR WORDS THAT AREN'T SYNONYMS

Canon is which books are in. **Translation** is which words render them. **Edition** is which notes, headings and apparatus surround them. **Lectionary** is which passages get read aloud, and when. An empire that can't change the canon can still change the other three, and the lectionary is the cheapest.

WHAT THE EMPIRE WOULD DO WITH THIS PAGE

POSSIBLE Never print it. A citizen who knows there are four collections knows there was a decision, and a citizen who knows there was a decision asks who made it. The Empire's Bible has to feel like weather, not legislation.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH COLLECTION IS THE EMPIRE'S OFFICIAL BIBLE, AND WHAT IT LEAVES OUT ON PURPOSE

WHAT YOU BROUGHT TO IT

YOURS

BASELINE

Answer these before the research goes further. They're a baseline, so later discoveries can be measured against something real and not against a memory that has quietly revised itself.

WHAT I THOUGHT THE BIBLE WAS BEFORE THIS PAGE

WHICH CANON OR EDITION I GREW UP AROUND: THE TRANSLATION, THE COVER, WHOSE COPY IT WAS

WHAT I WAS NEVER TOLD ABOUT HOW IT'S ORGANIZED

WHAT THIS CHANGES ABOUT THE EMPIRE'S OFFICIAL BIBLE

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

YOURS

PRACTICE

Run one tension yourself

Take one of the four conversations, or find your own, and work it. The point isn't to resolve it. The point is to be able to say exactly what's in dispute, which is the skill this whole part exists to build.

THE TENSION I'M WORKING

PASSAGES ON EACH SIDE

WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE, IN ONE SENTENCE, WITHOUT TAKING A SIDE

WHO GAINS FROM EACH READING

WHICH SIDE THE EMPIRE PRINTS, AND WHICH SIDE IT LETS PEOPLE SING

WHICH CHARACTER IS ON WHICH SIDE, AND WHETHER SHE KNOWS THERE IS A SIDE

Nothing written on this page is canon until it's logged. A discovery is a discovery, and a possibility isn't canon.

How it was assembled

INFORMATION

IRENAEUS, AGAINST HERESIES 3.11

NICAEA 325

I.2

There was never a room where the Bible was decided. It's the most useful thing to know about it and the hardest to hold onto, because a room would be easier to write about, and every empire in the book would prefer you believed in one.

USE CAME FIRST, RECOGNITION SECOND

Communities read, copied, argued over and prayed with these texts for generations before anyone published a list. Lists, when they came, mostly ratified habits already formed, and the habits were local.

FOUR GOSPELS, AND WHAT THAT MEANS

Other gospels existed and circulated. The four in the canon were the ones most widely read, earliest, across the most communities, and treated as apostolic in origin. Irenaeus was arguing for exactly four by about 180, which shows the number was contested enough to need defending. Calling them the gospels that "won" makes it sound like a vote. It was closer to a consensus hardening around what was already in use, with the theological arguments running alongside.

WHO ACTUALLY HELD THE AUTHORITY

Bishops wrote lists. Councils confirmed regional practice more often than they created it. Emperors funded copies, convened meetings and made some outcomes safer to hold than others. Constantine's role at Nicaea in 325 was real, and Nicaea wasn't about the canon. Local use was the slow current under all of it. Canon formation was a long negotiation among all four, and the balance shifted by century and region.

THE CLAIM WORTH KEEPING, STATED CAREFULLY

INTERPRETATION "Whoever can convene the meeting decides the canon" is too absolute, and it credits meetings with more than they did. What holds is that the people who could convene, fund, copy and distribute had outsized influence over which texts stayed in circulation, and circulation is most of what canon means in practice.

WHY THIS SEQUENCE IS SIX PAGES AND NOT ONE

POSSIBLE The Empire's account of its own Bible will be exactly one page long, and a single page can only give the compressed version.

NEH 8

SIRACH PROLOGUE

LXX

DEAD SEA SCROLLS 1947–1956

Torah, Prophets, Writings

Three divisions, settling at different times. The order they settled in is itself information: the most authoritative material stabilized first, and the edges were still being discussed centuries later.

DIVISION	ROUGHLY WHEN	WHAT WAS HAPPENING
TORAH	By the Persian period, about the fifth century BCE	Working as authoritative law for the restored community. Public reading is already an institution, and Nehemiah 8 shows the practice.
PROPHETS	Later, gradually	The Former and Latter Prophets circulate as a recognized body. By the second century BCE a writer can refer to "the law and the prophets" as a known pair.
WRITINGS	Last to settle	The loose end. Psalms and Proverbs uncontroversial. Esther, Ecclesiastes and Song of Songs still discussed in the rabbinic period.
SEPTUAGINT	Third century BCE onward	The Greek translation for Greek-speaking Jews, begun in Alexandria, with a wider and looser collection. Most New Testament writers quote it, which is why the Christian Old Testament inherited a different shape.

EARLY CHRISTIAN USE OF JEWISH SCRIPTURE

The first Christians had no New Testament. They had Israel's scriptures, read as testimony about what had just happened to them, which is a reading strategy and not a neutral inheritance. Every appeal to prophecy in the gospels is that strategy at work in public.

THE DEAD SEA SCROLLS, IN ONE PARAGRAPH

A library hidden near Qumran and found between 1947 and 1956, with biblical manuscripts about a thousand years older than the standard medieval Hebrew codices. They show a text remarkably stable in most places and genuinely variable in others, which corrects both the idea that the Hebrew Bible never changed and the idea that it was rewritten wholesale.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH DIVISION THE EMPIRE WOULD TEACH CHILDREN FIRST, AND WHICH IT WOULD SAVE FOR CLERGY

ATHANASIUS, FESTAL LETTER 39 (367)

HIPPO 393 · CARTHAGE 397

TRENT 1546

LANGTON · ESTIENNE 1551

A THOUSAND YEARS OF DECIDING

Approximate throughout, and contested in places, since dates in this field are arguments and not measurements. What the shape shows is that there was no single moment, and a very long tail.

WHEN	WHAT MOVED
ABOUT THE 5TH CENTURY BCE	The Torah working as authoritative law in the restored Judean community
3RD TO 1ST CENTURY BCE	The Septuagint translated in Alexandria. The Prophets recognized as a body. Wisdom and apocalyptic writing flourish.
ABOUT 50–60 CE	Paul's letters, the earliest New Testament documents, written to particular congregations before any gospel
ABOUT 70–100 CE	The gospels, written after the Temple's destruction in 70. The institution at the center of the story is already rubble when they're written.
2ND CENTURY	Marcion publishes a deliberately reduced collection, and the reaction sharpens everyone's sense that the boundary matters. Irenaeus argues for four gospels.
DATE DISPUTED	The Muratorian fragment lists much of what becomes the New Testament and leaves some out. **CONTESTED** Most date it to the late second century, a minority to the fourth.
3RD–4TH CENTURY	Eusebius sorts books into accepted, disputed and rejected, a working scholar's triage. Athanasius lists the twenty-seven books in 367.
LATE 4TH CENTURY	Councils at Hippo and Carthage in North Africa affirm lists close to today's. Jerome makes the Latin Vulgate and flags books he considers secondary, a distinction Rome didn't adopt.
MIDDLE AGES	Stable practice in the West. Eastern churches settle differently and not uniformly. Chapter divisions added in the thirteenth century, usually credited to Stephen Langton.
16TH CENTURY	Reformers separate or drop the deuterocanonical books, and Trent affirms them (1546). Robert Estienne's verse numbers (1551). Printing makes a household Bible possible, and a standardized one enforceable.
19TH–20TH CENTURY	Older manuscripts recovered, critical editions built, translations multiply. The text you can buy today rests on more evidence than any earlier century had.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE DATE ON THIS TIMELINE THE EMPIRE WOULD TEACH AS THE MOMENT THE BIBLE WAS FINISHED

MEGILLAH 7A

YADAYIM 3.5

EUSEBIUS, H.E. 3.25

LUTHER 1522

The ones they argued about

The tempting theory is that the disputed books were the ones hardest to preach from. It's too tidy. The recorded objections are usually about authorship, origin or particular content, and each book has its own reason. Read the right column as the reasons actually given.

BOOK	STATUS	WHAT THE OBJECTION WAS
ESTHER	Discussed	The Hebrew text never names God, and its festival, Purim, isn't in the Torah. It was received anyway, and the Greek version adds explicitly religious material.
SONG OF SONGS	Discussed	Explicit love poetry with no overt theology. Allegory (God and Israel, Christ and the church) became the standard defense, and it remains a reading.
ECCLESIASTES	Discussed	Its conclusions sit awkwardly beside the rest of wisdom literature. Many scholars read its closing verses as a later frame.
HEBREWS	Disputed	Anonymous. The West accepted it more slowly because Pauline authorship couldn't be shown, and nearly all scholars now agree Paul didn't write it.
JAMES	Disputed	Slow to circulate, and later a Reformation flashpoint over faith and works. Luther placed it at the back of his 1522 New Testament. It stayed in.
2 PETER	Disputed	The most doubted New Testament book in antiquity, on grounds of style and attribution. Its authorship is still a live question.
JUDE	Disputed	Quotes 1 Enoch, a book outside the canon it ended up in
REVELATION	Disputed	Accepted in the West, long resisted in the Greek East. It's scripture for the Orthodox churches and still isn't read aloud in their liturgy.

THE LAST ROW IS THE ONE TO STEAL

POSSIBLE A book can be fully canonical and never read aloud. It's a real historical arrangement and the most elegant instrument on this page. The Empire never has to ban anything.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH BOOKS ARE IN THE EMPIRE'S BIBLE AND NEVER IN ITS READINGS

APPLICATION

TKC: TR · CR · DR3

FR 33

Six instruments

The Empire doesn't need to change a word of the canon. Each instrument below is documented somewhere in history, and none requires editing scripture. Rank them by what the Empire would reach for first.

I · THE CALENDAR · RANK ___	Which feasts exist, which are civic, which are quietly dropped. A calendar decides what a population rehearses every year, and a holiday nobody keeps is a doctrine nobody remembers.
II · THE PUBLIC READINGS · RANK ___	The lectionary, the cheapest and strongest instrument here. For most people, scripture is what gets read aloud. The rest of the book is technically available and functionally silent.
III · CLERGY ACCESS · RANK ___	Who is trained, in what, and who may teach it. Control the training and you don't have to control the pulpit. **POSSIBLE** The Prelate's assessment team is this instrument with a person's name on it. The Prelate's working name is Prelate Aurelia (**FR 33**).
IV · THE SCHOOLBOOKS · RANK ___	Which stories children learn as stories, and in what order. The slowest instrument and the only one that compounds. A generation taught one shape of the book hears anything else as novelty.
V · DOMINION EDITIONS · RANK ___	Same canon, different apparatus, Dominion by Dominion. Headings, footnotes, cross-references and study notes do most of the interpretive work in any Bible a citizen owns, and none of it is scripture.
VI · COMMENTARY AND EMPHASIS · RANK ___	What the Broadcast says a passage means, repeated until the gloss can't be separated from the verse. The only instrument that works backward on people who already own the book.

WHICH INSTRUMENT THE EMPIRE USED FIRST, AND WHICH ONE IT'S STILL AFRAID TO USE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH INSTRUMENT THE EMPIRE USED FIRST, AND WHICH ONE IT'S STILL AFRAID TO USE

YOURS

WRITING

The Empire's own account

Write the Empire's version of this sequence, one page long, the way a Dominion schoolbook would tell it. Afterward, write what it left out. The gap between the two is a doctrine, and doctrines have authors.

THE EMPIRE'S ACCOUNT OF HOW ITS BIBLE CAME TO BE, IN THE VOICE OF A SCHOOLBOOK

WHAT IT LEAVES OUT, AND WHO WOULD BE DANGEROUS IF THEY KNEW IT

WHICH CHARACTER FINDS THE GAP FIRST, AND IN WHAT DOCUMENT

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

III–V

MODULES

Genres and the Two Testaments

What each kind of writing can and can't establish, and the shape of each half of the collection

FOURTEEN PAGES

INFORMATION

I.3

Eight genres

Genre determines what a passage is capable of establishing, and misreading it is the most common way a sincere reader reaches a confident wrong answer.

GENRE	WHAT IT'S TRYING TO DO	WHAT IT CAN'T ESTABLISH
LAW	Set a community's obligations, ritual, civil and moral, usually without separating them	Timeless policy. Legal codes address one society's cases.
NARRATIVE	Tell what happened, shaped for a purpose. It often reports behavior without endorsing it.	Approval. A story about polygamy isn't an argument for it.
POETRY	Make something felt, through image, parallel lines and intensity	Doctrine built on a metaphor read literally
WISDOM	Teach how the world generally works, and in Job and Ecclesiastes, how often it doesn't	Promises. A proverb is a pattern, not a guarantee.
PROPHECY	Deliver a message from God to a particular people at a particular moment: indictment, warning, consolation, sometimes prediction. Worship, idolatry and the character of God run throughout.	A calendar. Most prophecy speaks to its own audience's present, though some looks ahead and later readers read it forward.
GOSPEL	Present a life so the hearer has to reckon with it. Ancient biography with a purpose.	A transcript. Selection and arrangement are part of the form.
LETTER	Address a live situation in a named community, often with sustained theological argument	Rules without context. You're reading one side of a conversation.
APOCALYPTIC	Reveal what's really happening behind visible power, in symbols, for people who can't say it plainly	Forecasts of technology. Its symbols were readable to its first audience.

> **WHAT GENRE ERROR COSTS**
>
> Flattening a metaphor into a rule, or a story into an endorsement, has done real harm and still does. It's one mechanism among several, beside deliberate misuse, selective quotation and institutional interest, and it's worth naming exactly instead of blaming it for everything.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE GENRE I WAS TAUGHT TO READ WRONG

MATT 1

PS 88

LUKE 15

ISA 13–23

Forms inside the forms

Eight genres is the map. These are the units a passage is actually built from, and naming the unit usually settles what it can be used for.

GENEALOGY	A claim about belonging and legitimacy. Who's included is the argument. Matthew's four women are the point of Matthew's list.
LAMENT	Structured complaint, often addressed to God and often unresolved. Its place in the canon makes protest a sanctioned form of prayer.
HYMN	Communal praise, often older than the book it sits in, and often quoted because it was already familiar.
PROVERB	A compressed observation. Reliable as a pattern, dangerous as a promise, and cruel as a rebuke to someone suffering.
PARABLE	A story built to move the hearer. It usually turns on one hinge, and allegorizing every detail is how it gets defused.
ORACLE	A delivered message with a named addressee, often a foreign nation. Reading an oracle addressed to Babylon as addressed to you is a category error with a long history.
LEGAL CODE	Case law with penalties, comparable to other ancient Near Eastern codes. Comparison is where the distinctive parts show.
COURT HISTORY	A record written near power. Ask who commissioned it and what it leaves out.

THE GENRE TEST, BEFORE QUOTING ANYTHING

1. What kind of writing is this?
2. What is this kind of writing for?
3. What can it establish?
4. What can't it establish?
5. Am I using it for the thing it can do?
6. If not, is the misuse mine, or my character's?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE GENRE THE EMPIRE MISREADS ON PURPOSE, AND THE ONE IT MISREADS SINCERELY

TEMPLATE

ONE BLANK SPREAD PER GENRE

PHOTOCOPY BEFORE FILLING

GENRE: _____

WHAT THIS GENRE IS

WHAT IT'S TRYING TO DO

WHAT IT CAN ESTABLISH

WHAT IT CAN'T

THREE EXAMPLES, WITH REFERENCES

THE PASSAGE I'M PRACTICING ON

What the Empire does with it

HOW THE EMPIRE COULD MISUSE THIS GENRE: THE EXACT MECHANISM

WHO IN THE EMPIRE BENEFITS, AND WHO PAYS

WHICH CHARACTER READS THIS GENRE CORRECTLY, AND WHAT IT COSTS HER

MY QUESTIONS ABOUT THIS GENRE

WHAT I NEED TO RESEARCH BEFORE I WRITE THIS INTO A SCENE

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

INFORMATION

GEN–MAL

Six movements

An orientation, not a summary. The collection isn't arranged as one story, and these movements overlap, double back, and in places disagree about what happened.

MOVEMENT	WHAT IT'S ABOUT	THE QUESTION IT LEAVES OPEN
BEGINNINGS · GENESIS 1–11	Creation, rupture, flood and the scattering of peoples. Two creation accounts sit side by side, never reconciled.	Whether human power over others is part of the design or part of the damage
THE FAMILIES · GENESIS 12–50	A promise attached to one household and carried through four generations of deception, infertility, favoritism and migration	Why the promise keeps passing through the person who shouldn't have received it
EXODUS AND LAW · EXODUS–DEUTERONOMY	Liberation from imperial forced labor, forty years of learning to be a people, and a law given before the land is entered	Whether a people freed from empire can make law without reproducing it
LAND AND KINGS · JOSHUA–KINGS	Settlement, tribal instability, the demand for a king, David's house, two kingdoms and the slow loss of both	Whether monarchy was a concession, a failure or the plan
EXILE AND RETURN · EZRA, NEHEMIAH, CHRONICLES	Deportation, survival under foreign rule, partial return, rebuilding and a fierce argument about who belongs	Who counts, who's dissolved out of the community, and who writes the record
WISDOM AND PROPHECY · ACROSS THE COLLECTION	Two bodies of writing that comment on all the rest, one asking how to live well, one indicting how power behaves	Whether either one ever changed anything

THIS COMPANION'S LENS, DECLARED

INTERPRETATION Land runs through most of these movements: possession, loss, return, and who may hold it. It's a real and recurring concern of the collection. Reading the whole Old Testament as fundamentally about land is this companion's working lens, chosen because the Empire is a land empire. It isn't a neutral description of the material.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH MOVEMENT MY NOVEL IS SECRETLY RETELLING

2 CHR 36.23

MAL 4.5–6

2 KGS 17

2 KGS 25

WHERE THE STORY STOPS

The same books in two sequences, with two different endings, and so two different claims about what the collection is doing.

TANAKH ORDER

Torah, then Prophets, then Writings, closing with Chronicles and Cyrus's decree to go up and rebuild. It ends on return. **INTERPRETATION** The arc is instruction, then the record of failing it, then the literature of living with that, and the last word is permission to go home.

CHRISTIAN OLD TESTAMENT ORDER

Law, history, poetry, prophets, closing with Malachi and a promise of Elijah's return. It ends on anticipation. **INTERPRETATION** Resequenced this way, the collection reads as unfinished, which makes a New Testament feel like a continuation.

A ROUGH HISTORICAL SPINE

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
ABOUT 1000 BCE	The united monarchy of the biblical narrative, David and Solomon. **CONTESTED** Its scale is actively debated by archaeologists.
ABOUT 930 BCE	Division into Israel in the north and Judah in the south. Two kingdoms, two records, one collection.
722 BCE	Assyria destroys the northern kingdom. Deportation and dispersal.
587/586 BCE	Babylon destroys Jerusalem and the Temple and deports the elite. Much of the collection is written, edited or compiled in the shadow of this.
539 BCE	Persia takes Babylon, and return is permitted. Restoration is partial, contested and run under imperial authority.
332–63 BCE	Greek, then Roman, rule. Apocalyptic writing develops under occupation.

WHICH ORDERING THE EMPIRE PRINTS, AND WHAT ENDING IT NEEDS ITS CITIZENS TO EXPECT

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH ORDERING THE EMPIRE PRINTS, AND WHAT ENDING IT NEEDS ITS CITIZENS TO EXPECT

JUDG 21.25

1 SAM 8

RUTH 4

1–2 CHR

Say it more carefully

Four claims worth keeping, restated so they survive contact with someone who knows the material. The memorable version is on the left and the defensible version on the right, and the difference between them is the discipline of this companion.

THE MEMORABLE VERSION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY DEFENSIBLE
Judges says there was no king, so the book wants one.	The refrain, everyone doing what was right in his own eyes because there was no king, sits in a collection that's divided about monarchy. Samuel records the demand for a king as a rejection of God and lists what a king will take. Judges names the cost of no central authority without settling the argument.
Ruth answers it quietly.	INTERPRETATION A good reading. A Moabite woman's loyalty placed in David's genealogy reads as a counterargument to exclusion. The book doesn't announce itself as a rebuttal, and it can't be dated closely enough to prove intent.
Chronicles is the first act of imperial editing in the book itself.	Too confident. Chronicles retells Samuel and Kings with visible selection, David's worst material largely absent and worship in the foreground. It's an excellent case of a community re-telling its past for present purposes. Calling it the first, or imperial, overstates what can be shown.
The prophets are about how power treats the poor.	They're substantially about that, and reducing them to it loses most of the material: idolatry and false worship, foreign alliances, neighboring nations, ritual, exile and consolation, and the character of God. Keep the social indictment central without letting it become the whole subject.

> **WHY THIS PAGE EXISTS**
>
> A character who makes the left-hand claim can be brilliant and still wrong, and that's useful. A companion that makes it is unreliable, and in two years you won't be able to tell which of your own pages to trust.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH CHARACTER MAKES THE LEFT-COLUMN ARGUMENT, AND WHO CORRECTS HER

Nine threads

One line each, in your own words: what the collection actually does with each thread, and not what you were taught it does.

LAND

LAW

MONARCHY

EXILE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WOMEN

Nine threads, continued

COVENANT

EMPIRE

THE TEMPLE

WHO WRITES THE RECORD

Which movements are TKC

YOURS

TKC

Some movements don't belong in the novel. Mark the ones that do, and be specific about what they're doing there. A movement you can't give a job to is research, not material.

MOVEMENT	IN TKC?	DOING WHAT, AND FOR WHOM
Beginnings		
The families		
Exodus and law		
Land and kings		
Exile and return		
Wisdom and prophecy		

THE ONE MOVEMENT THE EMPIRE IS BUILT ON WITHOUT SAYING SO

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND ABOUT THIS COLLECTION

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

INFORMATION

ROMAN JUDEA

ACTS 2.44–45

Twenty-seven documents

Written across roughly a century by a movement inside the Roman Empire that had no state power. It wasn't powerless in every sense, and its social position varied by city, decade and class.

THE FIVE KINDS OF DOCUMENT

GOSPELS · 4	Narrative accounts of Jesus, written decades after the events, each for a particular community with particular concerns
ACTS · 1	The movement's spread from Jerusalem outward, by the author of Luke, as the second volume of one work
PAULINE LETTERS · 13	Letters to particular congregations about particular problems. Several contain sustained theological argument, and Romans is a worked case.
GENERAL LETTERS · 8	Hebrews and the letters attributed to James, Peter, John and Jude, for wider audiences and varied purposes
APOCALYPSE · 1	Revelation, a genre with its own conventions

COMPOSITION ORDER ISN'T CANONICAL ORDER

Paul's letters come first in time, written in the 50s before any gospel existed. The collection opens with the gospels because it's arranged as a story and not as an archive. Read in the order written, it shows a movement working out what it believed before anyone had written down the life it believed about.

THE ROMAN SETTING, WITHOUT FLATTENING IT

Occupation, client kings, taxation, crucifixion as public policy, the imperial cult, and a legal status for the movement that changed by place and period. It was tolerated in some cities, prosecuted in others, and not systematically outlawed across the empire for most of this century. Acts shows shared property in Jerusalem specifically, and Paul's letters show congregations with property, patrons and households.

> **FOR TKC**
>
> INTERPRETATION The useful fact isn't that the early movement was poor or illegal. A religion born under an empire was later administered by one, and the same texts served both.

Four accounts, one subject

They differ in selection, arrangement, emphasis and detail, and the differences are the most informative thing about them, because each shows what a particular community needed the story to do.

GOSPEL	ABOUT	WHAT IT EMPHASIZES	WHERE IT BEGINS
MARK	65–75	Urgency, secrecy, suffering. Shortest, probably earliest, and the source most scholars think Matthew and Luke used.	An adult at the river. No birth story.
MATTHEW	80–90	Fulfillment of Israel's scriptures, teaching in five great blocks, a new Moses. Written for a community deeply engaged with Jewish law.	A genealogy with four women in it, one of them Ruth
LUKE	80–95	The poor, women, outsiders and reversal, the powerful pulled down and the hungry filled. Volume one of two.	Two pregnancies and a song about thrones being emptied
JOHN	90–110	Identity and glory. Long discourses, no parables of the familiar kind, a different chronology and mostly its own material.	Before creation

WHY FOUR MATTERS FOR A NOVELIST

The canon keeps four versions instead of harmonizing them into one, and that decision shows on every page. INTERPRETATION An empire that wanted one official account had four to choose from and couldn't quietly reduce them, so the next best thing was deciding which one is read at which festival.

ACTS, AND WHAT IT'S DOING

A narrative of expansion from Jerusalem to Rome, shaped to show the movement's legitimacy and reach. Where Acts and Paul's own letters describe the same events they don't always agree, and historians treat the gap as real.

MARK
MATT
LUKE
JOHN
PART III, THE GOSPEL GRID

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH GOSPEL THE EMPIRE READS ALOUD MOST, AND WHICH ONE IT WOULD RATHER NOT

Who wrote what

ROM 16

1 COR 14.34–35

EPH 5

COL 3

1 TIM 2.11–15

Authorship is a scholarly question, not a settled fact, and the distinctions matter for TKC, because the letters most often quoted about households and women's silence are among those whose authorship is most disputed.

GROUP	SCHOLARLY VIEW	WHY IT MATTERS HERE
UNDISPUTED PAUL · ROM, 1–2 COR, GAL, PHIL, 1 THESS, PHLM	Broad agreement	Here Paul names women as coworkers, a deacon and an apostle. **CONTESTED** 1 Corinthians 14:34–35, the silence passage, sits in an undisputed letter, and some manuscripts place it after 14:40, so many scholars think it was added later.
DISPUTED PAUL · EPH, COL, 2 THESS	Genuinely divided	Ephesians and Colossians carry the household codes. Whether Paul wrote them changes what "the same author" can be claimed to mean.
PASTORALS · 1–2 TIM, TITUS	Most critical scholars: later	The strictest instructions about women teaching are here. Say "the Pauline letters" and not "Paul" when arguing across this line.
HEBREWS	Anonymous	By near consensus, it isn't Paul's. A sustained argument about priesthood and sacrifice, directly useful to any state that runs a temple.
OTHER ATTRIBUTED LETTERS · JAS, 1–2 PET, 1–3 JN, JUDE	Varies. 2 Peter most doubted.	Attributing a letter to a famous name was a convention with a range of practices, so flatly asserting or denying authorship is equally unsafe.

THE SENTENCE TO KEEP

INTERPRETATION Several of the passages that restrict women most come from letters whose authorship, or whose placement in the text, is most in question. **POSSIBLE** The Empire would never mention it, because the instruction's authority rests on the name attached.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH LETTERS THE EMPIRE BUILT ITS HOUSEHOLD LAW ON, AND WHO IN THE EMPIRE KNOWS THE AUTHORSHIP PROBLEM

Four ways to read it

All four are held by serious readers. This companion leans toward the first, and it's still a framework and not a fact about the text. In TKC the reading a character holds is a political position.

I · Resistance literature against Rome

Written for congregations under imperial pressure, using the conventions of apocalyptic to say what couldn't be said plainly. Strong internal support: seven cities, the imperial cult, a city on seven hills, a luxury economy described with contempt. Most historical-critical scholarship works here.

II · A sequence of future events

Read as a program of things still to come. Widely held in popular and some confessional traditions, with enormous cultural influence and a long record of specific predictions failing, which is part of the material too.

III · A cycle, not a timeline

The visions as recurring patterns of empire, judgment and endurance. Explains the repetition, seals, trumpets and bowls covering the same ground three times, better than a sequential reading does.

IV · Liturgy and vision

The book as worship: hymns, thrones, incense and a heavenly assembly, meant to reorder what the hearer thinks is ultimately in charge. The Eastern churches' reluctance to read it aloud sits oddly beside this, and both facts are true.

The two identifications everyone makes

INTERPRETATION The beast as an imperial power and the woman on the beast as a capital city are the readings the evidence best supports, and they're readings. What's nearly beyond argument is narrower: the book's targets are political and economic, and it expects its audience to recognize them.

REV 13

REV 17–18

REV 4–5

EASTERN LECTIONARY

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH READING IS OFFICIAL IN THE EMPIRE, AND WHICH ONE GETS SOMEONE ARRESTED

A RELIGION BORN UNDER EMPIRE

YOURS

WRITING

The New Testament was written by people with no state power. The Empire is a state that runs on it. Work the distance between those two sentences.

WHICH PASSAGES BECOME EASIER TO USE ONCE YOU HOLD POWER, AND WHY

WHICH ONES BECOME EMBARRASSING, AND HOW THE EMPIRE HANDLES THEM

THE VERSE EDEN WAS TAUGHT AS COMFORT AND LATER READS AS INSTRUCTION

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

VI–IX

MODULES

Translation, Context, Fault Lines

How translation decisions get made, the eight questions, the four kinds of disagreement, and the household verse worked all the way through

EIGHTEEN PAGES

INFORMATION

MASORETES

NA28 · UBS5

I.4

Translation, and how to compare it

The old title asked which translation to trust. It's the wrong question, because it implies one exists that never needs checking. The goal is to understand how translation decisions get made, so you can see one being made and say what it did.

THREE LANGUAGES

HEBREW	Most of the Old Testament. Written originally without vowels. The vowel points were added centuries later by the Masoretes, scribes preserving how the text was read aloud, so a consonantal text can sometimes be voiced more than one way, and where it can, translators choose.
ARAMAIC	Parts of Daniel and Ezra, and the everyday speech of Judea in the first century. Jesus taught in it, and the gospels record him in Greek.
GREEK	The New Testament, in Koine, the common Greek of the eastern Mediterranean. It isn't uniform: Mark's is rough and Hebrews' is polished. Translations that flatten every book to one register lose that.

MANUSCRIPTS AND VARIANTS

No original of any biblical book survives. What exists is thousands of copies, and they differ, overwhelmingly in spelling, word order and obvious slips, and occasionally in something substantive. Textual criticism reconstructs the earliest recoverable text from that evidence. A few famous passages are missing from the earliest manuscripts, and reputable Bibles say so in a footnote: the longer ending of Mark (16:9–20), the woman caught in adultery (John 7:53–8:11), and the Trinitarian clause in 1 John 5:7–8.

WHERE DIFFERENCES ACTUALLY COME FROM

Most differences between translations aren't ideological. They come from a genuinely ambiguous word, a construction with no clean English equivalent, a choice of register, or a choice between manuscripts. Some are theologically motivated, and those are worth finding, but if you assume every difference is, you won't be able to spot the real ones.

> **YOU DON'T NEED THE LANGUAGES**
>
> You need to know where the decisions live, and to look at more than one Bible when a sentence is doing something to somebody.

The spectrum

It isn't a scale from honest to dishonest. It runs from keeping the structure of the original to keeping its effect on the reader, and every point on it gives something up.

APPROACH	WHAT IT PRIORITIZES	WHAT IT GIVES UP
INTERLINEAR	Word-for-word correspondence, original order under the line	Readability. A study tool, not a Bible.
FORMAL ("LITERAL") · KJV, NASB, ESV	The original's grammar and ambiguity, kept even where English strains	Clarity in places. An ambiguity preserved is still one you have to resolve.
MIDDLE · NIV, NRSV, CSB	Accuracy in natural English	Some seams
FUNCTIONAL ("DYNAMIC") · NLT, GOOD NEWS	What the sentence does, in idiomatic English	Where the original was ambiguous, the translator has already chosen for you
PARAPHRASE · THE MESSAGE	Immediate impact, often one author's voice	Any claim to precision. Good for hearing a passage fresh, useless for an argument about wording.
COMMITTEE OR SOLO	Committees give consistency, individuals give voice. Committees have institutional homes, traditions, funders and audiences.	Neither is neutral, and neither is disqualified. Knowing who made it is part of reading it.

KJV · NASB · ESV

NIV · NRSV · CSB

NLT

THE MESSAGE

WHY THE FOOTNOTES MATTER MORE THAN THE TRANSLATION YOU CHOSE

A footnote that says "or," "other manuscripts read," or "Greek uncertain" is the translator telling you a decision happened here. When a verse is being used against someone, check whether the page admits an alternative.

CHAPTERS, VERSES AND HEADINGS AREN'T SCRIPTURE

Chapter divisions came in the thirteenth century, verse numbers in the sixteenth, and section headings from modern editors. They make the text findable and quotable, and they also impose breaks the author didn't write. Quoting a verse is normal. The question is whether the unit you quoted is doing the work of the unit around it.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO AUTHORIZED THE EMPIRE'S TRANSLATION, AND WHAT ITS FOOTNOTES ARE ALLOWED TO SAY

PASSAGE: _____

TEMPLATE

ONE SPREAD PER PASSAGE

PHOTOCOPY BEFORE FILLING

FOUR RENDERINGS. NAME THE TRANSLATION, THEN COPY THE WORDING EXACTLY.

TRANSLATION	HOW IT READS

WHAT THE FOOTNOTES ADMIT, IN ANY OF THE FOUR

TEMPLATE

THE DIFFERENCE

WHAT THE DIFFERENCE DOES

THE WORD OR PHRASE THEY HANDLE DIFFERENTLY

THE CHOICE EACH ONE MADE. DESCRIBE IT, DON'T RANK IT.

AMBIGUITY, IDIOM, MANUSCRIPT, OR THEOLOGY?

DOES THE DIFFERENCE CHANGE WHAT ANYONE MUST DO?

WHICH RENDERING THE EMPIRE PRINTS, AND WHAT IT GAINS

WHAT I STILL NEED A REAL SOURCE FOR BEFORE I USE THIS IN A SCENE

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO.

DATE

Four triggers

LEXICON

COMMENTARY

BDB · HALOT · BDAG

Comparing English Bibles gets you a long way. These four situations mean stop and find a real source, a lexicon, a commentary or a scholar, before it goes into the novel as a claim.

I · THE ARGUMENT RESTS ON ONE WORD

If a whole doctrine hangs on the range of a single term, the range is the question, and English can't answer it. The household verse is in exactly this situation.

II · THE TRANSLATIONS SPLIT ALONG DENOMINATIONAL LINES

When the pattern of who renders it which way matches the pattern of who teaches what, something besides grammar is operating, and you need to be able to name it exactly.

III · A FOOTNOTE SAYS THE TEXT IS UNCERTAIN

Take the admission seriously. The manuscripts disagree or the syntax won't resolve, and building a scene on the resolved version is building on a choice.

IV · YOU'RE ABOUT TO SAY WHAT THE ORIGINAL "REALLY" MEANS

The most dangerous sentence available to a non-specialist, and one used with total confidence by people on every side. A character may say it. The companion may not, without a source.

THE CLAIMS ABOUT THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGES I'VE BEEN REPEATING WITHOUT CHECKING

METHOD

I.5

Eight Questions

Run all eight, in order, before deciding what a passage means. They won't make you an expert, but most confident misuse of scripture happens by skipping one, and skipping is easy to catch in yourself if you have a list.

1 · WHAT KIND OF TEXT IS THIS?	Genre first, always. It decides what the passage can establish before any other question is worth asking.
2 · WHO'S SPEAKING?	The narrator, a character, God as quoted, a rival, a friend who turns out to be wrong. Job's comforters are in the Bible and they're mistaken, and the book says so.
3 · TO WHOM?	A congregation with a particular problem, a king, a foreign nation, one person. Applying an oracle addressed to Babylon to yourself is a category error with a long history.
4 · WHAT COMES BEFORE AND AFTER?	Read the paragraph, then the chapter. Most weaponized verses only work once the sentences on either side have been cut.
5 · WHAT WORLD PRODUCED IT?	Empire, occupation, exile, monarchy, the household economy, the legal status of women and slaves. The setting is often the subject.
6 · WHAT DO THE WORDS DO?	Command, describe, lament, promise, threaten, concede, argue. Compare two translations and see whether they agree about which.
7 · WHO GAINS FROM THIS READING?	Ask it of every reading, including the one you prefer. A reading that benefits you isn't wrong because of it, and it's worth checking twice.
8 · WHAT DOES THIS READING COST?	And who pays. **POSSIBLE** The Empire has never asked this one out loud, and Eden eventually can't stop asking it.

> **WHAT THE METHOD BUYS YOU**
>
> It doesn't buy authority over people who quote this book for a living. Many of them run these questions better than you will. It buys the ability to tell a reading that has done the work from one that skipped a step, including your own, and to say which step.

PASSAGE: _____

TRANSLATION USED

REFERENCE

1 · GENRE

2 · SPEAKER

3 · AUDIENCE

4 · WHAT SURROUNDS IT

5 · HISTORICAL CONTEXT: WHAT WORLD PRODUCED IT

6 · WHAT THE WORDS DO, AND WHETHER TWO TRANSLATIONS AGREE

THE INTERPRETIVE DISPUTE: WHO READS IT WHICH WAY, AND ON WHAT EVIDENCE

TEMPLATE

WHO GAINS, WHO PAYS

WHO GAINS, WHO PAYS

7 · WHO GAINS FROM EACH READING

8 · WHAT EACH READING COSTS, AND WHO PAYS IT

THE EMPIRE'S OFFICIAL READING, AND HOW IT'S TAUGHT

WHERE I CURRENTLY LAND, IN MY OWN WORDS

RESEARCH STILL NEEDED

WHICH CHARACTER HOLDS WHICH READING

THE SCENE, CHAPTER OR DOCTRINE THIS FEEDS

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO.

DATE

Eight fault lines

The eight places where reading this book divides people, and where the Empire has a doctrine. Research won't produce agreement on any of them, but it reliably rules out weak claims and shows what the argument is actually about.

FAULT LINE	WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE	WHERE TKC USES IT
HEADSHIP	The range of one Greek noun, the reach of the mutual-submission verse, and what carries over from a Roman household code	The Binding. Every household in the Empire.
WOMEN SPEAKING	Restriction passages in the Pauline letters set against the undisputed letters, which name women as coworkers, a deacon and an apostle. Authorship and dating carry weight here.	The Vowed. Who may teach, and who may only recite.
SLAVERY	Texts that regulate slavery without abolishing it, and the principle by which a tradition later called it wrong. The verses aren't in doubt. The principle is the argument.	Designation and labor tracks. Who can be assigned.
DIVINE VIOLENCE	Conquest narratives and judgment oracles: history, theological rhetoric, later reflection or ancient war convention, and how any of it fits a God described elsewhere as merciful	The Fall. Every purge called cleansing.
OBEDIENCE TO RULERS	Romans 13 against the prophets, Revelation and the movement's own martyrs. General principle, or advice to a vulnerable congregation in the imperial capital?	The Empire's most quoted text. Its whole legitimacy.
WEALTH	Whether the warnings target attachment, structural injustice or wealth itself, and how they sit beside the prosperity language of the wisdom books	Crownward theology. Blessing as evidence of favor.
PURITY AND THE BODY	Which rules are which, and by whose framework. The ritual and moral distinction is a later category applied to the texts, not a label printed in them.	Designation exams, the Salt Ceremony, fertility review
THE END OF THINGS	Apocalyptic read as address to its own moment, as a future program, as a recurring pattern, or as liturgy	Whose reading is orthodoxy, and whose is sedition

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE FAULT LINE MY NOVEL STANDS ON HARDEST

Not all contested alike

The most important distinction in this part. Treating all four as equally open is how a companion becomes useless, and how a well-read person ends up unable to say that something is simply false.

I · SERIOUS SCHOLARLY DISPUTE

Specialists with the languages, the manuscripts and the historical training disagree, and each side can state the other's evidence. The range of *kephalē*. The authorship of Ephesians. Represent both, and don't pick a winner in the companion's own voice.

II · DENOMINATIONAL OR TRADITIONAL DISAGREEMENT

Communities differ because of their confessions, their governance and inherited practice, more than because the evidence is contested. Who may be ordained. Whether Revelation is read aloud. Name the tradition instead of treating its position as the neutral one.

III · OPEN THEOLOGICAL QUESTIONS

Questions the text raises and doesn't close, where evidence runs out and judgment begins. What the conquest narratives say about God. Whether Job is ever answered. These stay open honestly, and they're where a novel does its best work.

IV · UNSUPPORTED CLAIMS

Claims that fail on the evidence: invented etymologies, a word supposedly mistranslated in every Bible, a council that decided something it never discussed. These are wrong, and the companion can say so, while noting that a character may believe one sincerely and build a life on it. The curse of Ham is in this category (Genesis dossier).

THE SORTING QUESTION

Before writing any dispute into a scene, ask which of the four it is. Category I earns two credible characters. Category IV earns one character who's wrong and one who knows it, and that's a different scene entirely.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE CATEGORY IV CLAIM THE EMPIRE TEACHES AS SETTLED FACT

Fault line: _____

TEMPLATE

PHOTOCOPY BEFORE FILLING

KIND: I / II / III / IV

THE PASSAGES, WITH REFERENCES

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

THE MAJOR READINGS

THE READING	WHO HOLDS IT	ON WHAT EVIDENCE

The Empire and the people

WHAT THE EMPIRE OFFICIALLY TEACHES

WHAT IT SUPPRESSES, AND HOW

WHO IN THE NOVEL STANDS WHERE

CHARACTER	AGREES · DOUBTS · RESISTS · REINTERPRETS	WHAT IT COSTS HER, AND WHEN SHE LEARNED IT

WHAT STAYS UNRESOLVED, AND SHOULD

WHAT I STILL NEED A SOURCE FOR

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. **DATE**

Ephesians 5

EPH 5.18–6.9

P46 · VATICANUS

SINAITICUS · ALEXANDRINUS

METZGER, TEXTUAL COMMENTARY

GURRY, NTS 2021

I.7

The worked example, because the Empire's household law is built on this passage and because nearly everything hard about reading scripture is in it at once: a disputed author, a supplied verb, a contested word, a Roman legal background, and a verse break in the wrong place.

WHERE THE SENTENCE ACTUALLY STARTS

Verse 21 tells the whole congregation to submit to one another. Verse 22 addresses wives. In P46 and Codex Vaticanus, verse 22 has no verb at all, and Clement of Alexandria quotes it the same way, so the instruction to wives borrows the participle of verse 21, and the two verses are one grammatical movement. Codex Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus and most later manuscripts supply a verb, and most English Bibles supply one too, with a section heading printed between the verses. The heading is modern apparatus, not scripture.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION It listed Sinaiticus among the verbless witnesses. Sinaiticus has the verb (*hypotassesthōsan*). The verbless witnesses are P46 and Vaticanus.

WHAT THE PARTICIPLE SETTLES, AND WHAT IT DOESN'T

The grammatical link isn't in dispute. What it implies is. One reading holds that mutual submission in 21 governs everything after it. Another holds that 21 introduces submission in general and 22 onward specifies its ordered forms. Bruce Metzger's committee preferred the verbless text, and Peter Gurry (New Testament Studies, 2021) argues the verb is original. The grammar alone doesn't decide the meaning, and anyone who says the Greek settles it is overselling, in either direction.

THE AUTHORSHIP QUESTION

Ephesians is one of the disputed letters. Whether Paul wrote it divides scholars, which affects any argument that runs "the same author who names women as coworkers also said this."

THE STRUCTURAL LESSON

Quote verse 22 alone and you have a rule for wives. Quote 21 through 33 and you have a passage that gives husbands three times as many verses (nine to three) and about 116 Greek words to the wives' 40 (Mowczko). **INTERPRETATION** The mechanism isn't mistranslation. It's fragment selection, plus a heading, plus teaching the doctrine before anyone reads the paragraph. Any institution with a lectionary and a catechism can do it without altering a word.

KEPHALĒ

BEDALE 1954

GRUDEM, TRINJ 1985

FITZMYER 1989

CERVIN 1989

BDAG

Head

The Greek word is kephalē. Its range in this period is one of the most argued questions in New Testament lexicography, and the dispute is genuine on both sides.

PROPOSED SENSE	THE CASE FOR IT, AND THE STRAIN AGAINST IT
AUTHORITY OVER	Well attested for rulers and governing bodies, and the natural reading if the passage is arranging a hierarchy. Wayne Grudem surveyed 2,336 instances (1985) and argued "source" is rare, and Joseph Fitzmyer (1989) agreed. Strain: the passage defines the husband's headship by self-giving and nourishing, and gives husbands no order anywhere.
SOURCE OR ORIGIN	Attested in some contexts, a river's head, a source of supply, and fits the body imagery, where the head supplies and the body grows. Stephen Bedale (1954) began the modern debate with it, and Catherine Kroeger and Philip Payne developed it. Strain: how common this sense was in ordinary first-century use is exactly what's disputed.
PREEMINENCE	Foremost, most prominent, first in honor, with no command attached. Richard Cervin's reply to Grudem (1989) is usually grouped here. Strain: honor and authority are hard to separate in a society organized around both.
METAPHOR, UNRESOLVED	The writer is working an extended body metaphor and didn't intend an institutional definition, which would explain why readers have pulled incompatible institutions out of it for two thousand years.

THE WORD RENDERED "SUBMIT"

Hypotassō means to arrange oneself under someone. The middle voice is often read as something the subject does herself, and scholars disagree about how much weight that can bear. **INTERPRETATION** A voluntary act inside a legal system where the alternative is ruin is voluntary only in a limited sense. **POSSIBLE** The Empire understands this perfectly. It never forces. It makes the alternative unlivable.

WHAT NOT TO DO WITH THIS PAGE

Don't use it to announce that the Greek has been solved and the hierarchy dissolved. The point is to be able to say which sense a reading assumes and what that assumption costs.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH SENSE THE EMPIRE'S DOCTRINE ASSUMES, AND WHETHER ITS PRELATES KNOW THERE'S A CHOICE

ARISTOTLE, POLITICS I

BALCH, LET WIVES BE SUBMISSIVE (1981)

EPH 5.25–33

EPH 6.5–9

THE HOUSEHOLD CODE

Wives, children and slaves, addressed in that order, isn't an invention of this letter. It's a recognizable Greco-Roman form, instruction on managing a household, which was a political unit as much as a domestic one, because the ordered household was understood as the foundation of the ordered state.

WHAT THE FORM ASSUMES

A male head with legal authority over wife, children and enslaved people, the household as an economic enterprise, and the state's interest in its order. Aristotle's *Politics* (Book I) sets out the three pairs. A first-century reader would recognize the shape at once, and would notice the departures.

WHERE THIS VERSION DEPARTS FROM THE FORM

It addresses the subordinate parties directly as moral agents. It gives the husband the longer and harder instruction. It grounds the arrangement in Christ's self-giving and not in nature or the head's prerogative. Whether that amounts to subverting the code, a Christianized version of it, or an accommodation that made the movement socially survivable is a live argument, and all three are held by people who've done the work. David Balch argued that 1 Peter's code helped present the movement as respectable to suspicious outsiders.

THE INSTRUCTIONS TO HUSBANDS

Love as Christ loved and gave himself up. Nourish and cherish as your own body. The passage gives husbands no command to rule, enforce or correct. INTERPRETATION A doctrine of headship that produces enforcement is drawing on the noun in verse 23, and not on anything the passage tells husbands to do.

THE PART NOBODY QUOTES AT WEDDINGS

The same code goes on to enslaved people and their masters (6:5–9). An institution that treats the wives section as timeless and the slavery section as historically conditioned is making an interpretive decision it usually declines to defend. Noticing that is the most useful single move available to a character inside such an institution.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

HOW THE EMPIRE HANDLES THE SLAVERY SECTION OF THE SAME PASSAGE

COMPLEMENTARIAN

EGALITARIAN

DANVERS 1987

CBE 1987

PART IV

Four positions

Held by real people with real arguments. Learn to state each one in its own terms before deciding anything. A character who can only caricature the other reading hasn't thought about it yet.

POSITION	WHAT IT HOLDS, AND ON WHAT EVIDENCE	ITS HARDEST PROBLEM
ORDERED ROLES (COMPLEMENTARIAN)	Distinct and permanent roles: the husband leads, the wife submits, both equal in worth. Rests on the plain sense of headship in the era's usage and on the order of the code itself.	Nothing in the passage authorizes enforcement, and verse 21 addresses everyone
MUTUAL SUBMISSION (EGALITARIAN)	Verse 21 governs the whole section, and the household instructions apply a shared obligation. Rests on the grammar of the participle and the content of the husbands' instructions.	The instructions are still asymmetrical, and only wives are told to submit
HISTORICALLY SITUATED	A first-century congregation taught to live inside an existing legal structure without being destroyed by it. Rests on the household-code parallels and the letter's occasional character.	It needs a principle for deciding what carries over to other centuries, and stating that principle is hard
ACCOMMODATION	A movement softening its radical edge to survive scrutiny. Rests on the trajectory from the undisputed letters toward the Pastorals.	It depends on authorship and dating questions that aren't settled

The modern American debate took its current shape in 1987, with the complementarian Danvers Statement and the founding of Christians for Biblical Equality. See Part IV.

ASSIGN ONE POSITION TO EACH CHARACTER WHO HAS AN OPINION, THEN ONE TO A CHARACTER WHO'S NEVER BEEN TOLD THERE'S MORE THAN ONE

ASSIGN ONE POSITION TO EACH CHARACTER WHO HAS AN OPINION, THEN ONE TO A CHARACTER WHO'S NEVER BEEN TOLD THERE'S MORE THAN ONE

METHOD, WORKED

EPH 5.21–6.9

THE METHOD, WORKED

The eight questions, answered on this passage, so you can see a completed run before doing your own.

1 · KIND OF TEXT	A letter containing a household code: correspondence, not legislation, with a recognizable moral-instruction form inside it.
2 · SPEAKER	The letter's author, writing in Paul's name. **CONTESTED** whether Paul wrote it. It's neither a narrator reporting nor God quoted directly.
3 · AUDIENCE	A congregation, or several, in the Roman province of Asia. Wives, husbands, children and enslaved people are all addressed as present and listening.
4 · BEFORE AND AFTER	Before: mutual submission, addressed to all. After: husbands, then children and parents, then slaves and masters. The wives' instruction is the shortest unit in the sequence.
5 · THE WORLD	Roman legal households with a male head, an economy that included slavery, a state invested in domestic order, and a small movement under intermittent suspicion.
6 · WHAT THE WORDS DO	Instruct, in some manuscripts through a participle hanging on the previous sentence. One contested noun. The husbands' portion is longer and makes the heavier demand.
7 · WHO GAINS	From the fragment: whoever holds household authority, and any state that needs orderly households. From the whole passage: much less clear, which is why the fragment is what gets printed.
8 · WHAT IT COSTS	Under the fragment reading, a woman's standing depends on a man's character, with no recourse written into the text. Ask who in Aurelia pays that, and what she's told when she says so.

WHERE MY OWN FIRST RUN OF THIS PASSAGE WENT WRONG

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHERE MY OWN FIRST RUN OF THIS PASSAGE WENT WRONG

YOURS

TKC: CR · DOM · DR3

What this is for

This passage is the seed of the Binding, the Covenant and every household in the Empire (CR). Write what the Empire did with it, and what you were taught about it long before you read the paragraph.

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT THIS PASSAGE MEANT, AND WHO TAUGHT ME

THE EMPIRE'S OFFICIAL DOCTRINE OF HEADSHIP, IN THE EMPIRE'S OWN WORDS

WHICH VERSES THE TEMPLE PRINTS, AND WHICH IT LEAVES FOR CLERGY

THE MOMENT EDEN READS THE WHOLE PARAGRAPH FOR THE FIRST TIME

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____